Core Principles and Best Practice in Establishing Community-Driven Sport Spaces

What love.fútbol has learned from 20 years of experience and 100+ sports spaces established

Introduction

At love.fútbol, our Community-Driven™ methodology is about the process just as much as it is about the product. This document, Community-Driven Best Practices, captures key insights from nearly two decades of experience implementing sport spaces across five continents.

Rather than treating community engagement and sustainability as an isolated step, our model embeds it throughout every phase of the project. From understanding local realities, to co-designing the space, to actively promoting long-term sustainability and legacy. By following these best practices, we aim to support communities in co-creating spaces that reflect their identity, take true ownership, and activate them with purpose and pride.

Core Principles

- Local Reality
- Community-Driven Development
- Asset-Based Development
- Partnership
- Sustainability

Best Practices for Community-Driven Implementation

Each core principle informs how we ensure that sports spaces are community-driven. As such, we embed them throughout the 6 key phases of each sports space project we complete to ensure local needs are met, and community members are mobilized as leaders throughout the process. Each project's key phases are outlined below:



SITE IDENTIFICATION

Understanding



PROJECT APPROVAL

Formalizing



COMMUNITY MOBILIZATION

Connecting



PROJECT DEVELOPMENT

Building



INAUGURATION

Celebrating



POST-PROJECT

Monitoring and Supporting

Below we walk you through key steps you can activate to ensure your local sports space is community-driven.

1. Community and Partnership Feasibility Review

Before formal engagement begins, it is essential to conduct an initial assessment to evaluate the community's need for public play spaces, gauge local interest and leadership capacity, and assess the potential for project partnerships alongside long-term sustainability. This review ensures the project design is locally relevant and aligned with community interests and governance capacity. By confirming that conditions are in place for a meaningful, sustainable, and community-led initiative, this step lays the groundwork for everything that follows.

2. Asset Mapping and Engagement Strategy

This involves identifying community members, youth, and diverse local stakeholders while mapping existing assets to better understand local history, strengths, and opportunities.
Start by mapping your community's assets by exploring the following questions:

- Who do you know?
- Who do you interact with on a regular basis?
- Who in your community has skills or interests that complement your project?
- Brainstorm every resource below – individuals, businesses, organizations, and institutions.

A clear engagement strategy is developed to guide informal interactions and relationship-building, prioritizing authentic conversations over formal processes. During this stage, collect essential information from landowners and stakeholders about gaps and challenges related to maintaining and activating the space, explore opportunities for collaboration, and present governance and public-community partnership models. Trust-building, observation, and strategic alignment are prioritized, always approaching the community with open questions rather than predetermined answers.

3. Define the Community Narrative and Project Structure

With a solid understanding of local assets and challenges, it's important to translate these insights into a shared community narrative, built and affirmed by the community. A collective story of purpose and transformation. This process clarifies community priorities such as safety, access, inclusion, and youth leadership, co-defining the desired impact with those involved. Designing the space with local input becomes essential at this stage, ensuring it is not only relevant but also sustainable in the long term. Solutions and management structures are analyzed and aligned with the community's capacity, so the final design reflects both aspirations and practical realities.



4. Identify and Assess Construction Partners

Selecting the right construction partner is a critical component of ensuring quality and alignment with project goals. At least three quotations should be obtained to allow for an informed decision. Partners are assessed not just on price but also on the durability of their product, their understanding of local conditions, and their experience working with social organizations. This careful selection process helps guarantee that the construction phase supports the broader community-driven objectives rather than becoming a disconnected or purely transactional step.

5. Design for Sustainability from Day One

Sustainability is integrated and embedded into the project from the very beginning. Future users are involved at every step, from planning to design, so that expectations around access, maintenance, and programming are clear and shared. Cultivating early ownership by identifying local leaders and fostering a long-term mindset of responsibility helps create spaces that do not just open but continue to thrive well beyond the formal project period. This mindset contributes to developing a space that serves as a catalyzer and platform for ongoing community growth and development.

6. Prioritize Human Connection

The Engagement Phase is the foundation of everything we do at love.fútbol. It’s where transformation truly begins, not with bricks, but with people. This phase is about human connection: listening, learning, and building trust through informal, consistent, and authentic interactions.

We meet people where they are - on the pitch, at home, in community spaces - learning local stories, identifying leadership structures, social dynamics, and hidden barriers. Through this process, we don’t just gather information, we build relationships. This sets the tone for everything that follows. By the time construction begins, the foundation is already in place: one built on trust, shared ownership, and community leadership, laying the groundwork for lasting impact.



7. Facilitate a Community-Driven Process

love.fútbol's role is to facilitate, not dictate. Throughout the project, we consciously put as much control as possible in the hands of the community. This means understanding our role as guides and creating space for the community to lead. Key individuals, groups, and organizations interested in contributing directly to the project are identified early. Together, we define and distribute essential roles around the project's management and sustainability, ensuring that leadership and ownership are genuinely community-driven.

8. Community Build Day and Inauguration

The Build Day and Inauguration represent tangible opportunities for community members and project stakeholders to connect in person and build on a shared sense of ownership and pride. These events serve as moments of collective celebration, reinforcing the idea that the space belongs to the community. They also help solidify relationships with partners and supporters, making visible the community's leadership and the broader impact of the project.

9. Sustainability Plans and Local Capacity

While the construction takes place, equal focus is placed on developing management and financial tools to strengthen local capacity that support long-term sustainability. Together with the community, we co-create context-specific resources such as pitch calendars, maintenance plans, governance models, and revenue-generation strategies like raffles, sponsorships, tournament & leagues, and grant-writing. Beyond providing tools, we offer practical training in programming, coordination, fundraising, and legal or administrative support to promote autonomy and resilience.



10. Activate the Space with Purpose

After the space is built, it must be activated with clear intention and purpose. Launching the space includes implementing inclusive, values-based programming and community-led leagues that bring it to life as a true platform for social development. Calendar planning for the use of the space focuses on equitable access to diverse groups, ensuring time is equally blocked for both structured and unstructured play. Additionally, community events and cultural celebrations are organized to foster pride, increase visibility, and strengthen community bonds. The inauguration and related activities also deepen connections with partners and supporters, highlighting the broader significance of the project.

11. Provide Ongoing Support and Stewardship

Effective stewardship practices help communities monitor usage, collect relevant data, and identify risks early, while also connecting them to new opportunities for growth and sustainability. Because all communities face fluctuations and challenges, building a framework for ongoing support and risk identification strengthens long-term outcomes.

The objective is to maintain momentum and reinforce community leadership, not to create dependency on external resources.



We'd love your feedback.

Do these principles and best practices resonate with your work or interests? Let us know how this guide supports your thinking—or what questions it raises. We're always learning and evolving, and your perspective matters.

Interested in bringing a community-driven sport space to life?

Whether you're exploring a new build, a refurbishment, or simply looking to embed a more community-driven process into your existing project, we'd be happy to collaborate.

Get in touch with us at info@lovefutbol.org to start a conversation.